Eco-Development

The eco-development view stresses the co-evolution of human society and ecosystems on an equal basis. The earth is seen as a *closed ecological system* and therefore the principle challenge is to **'ecologize the economy'**. This view is less anthropocentric than the resource management view, emphasising that nature has an intrinsic value that is independent of the value placed upon it by the human economy. Thus, this view has a moral or *ethical dimension* that implies a transformation of societal attitudes toward nature. This dimension was not assumed in the previous ideas. The 'problem' in this case is that the scale of human economic growth is inconsistent with the long-term co-existence of humankind with nature. Sustainability is defined as non-decreasing stocks of human and natural capital maintained independently which means no substitutability between technology and natural resources.[24] In the face of uncertainty about ecological thresholds and the world's carrying capacity, the 'precautionary principle' implies that new technologies or development projects must demonstrate that they are consistent with sustainability as defined above, before they are adopted. Progress is measured not in terms of efficiency, but in terms of the health of regional ecosystems as well as human health.[25]

Policy objectives under this view would include moving toward a ***closed materials cycle***. The economy would rely principally on *renewable sources* of energy and materials, extracted at rates that would not affect ecological health. The non-renewable resources would be recovered and recycled indefinitely. Instead of tradable pollution permits, tradable permits might be issued for the extraction of a fixed quantity of non-renewable materials. The production/consumption system would be restructured to optimise the utilisation of goods to satisfy essential human needs, rather than the ownership of goods to satisfy *'frivolous wants'*. Green products and technologies would avoid the use of materials that are toxic to humans or ecological systems, substitute renewable for nonrenewable materials, and ensure that nonrenewable materials could be readily recovered for recycling.